

or they better be built well enough to stand rigorous overclocking. Yes, this also means large, attractive and overkill heatsink and heatpipe cooling solutions with lots of shiny copper – after all, a board that costs this much should look the part as well.

Gamers and enthusiasts looking for SLI and Crossfire support as well as DDR3 will also likely find something in the category. A total of nine boards featured in this category; four NVIDIA 790i solutions, four Intel X48 solutions and a single P45 solution.

Features

NVIDIAs 790i SLI is a unique offering in the way that this chipset supports three x16 PCIe lanes for 3-way SLI using the full bandwidth of the PCIe slot. Both the 780i and the 790i use the same Southbridge, which is nothing more than a 570i SLI chip which provides the bandwidth for the extra PCIe lanes. Three of the 790i SLI boards from EVGA, XFX and ZOTAC are identical in terms of build, design and features. The only difference is EVGA provides better quality SATA and PATA cables and ZOTAC provides a WLAN AP kit. ASUS' Striker 2 NSE is unique – it's built around the same layout as the ASUS Striker 2 Formula but supports DDR3. And

this is the only major difference. The build quality is exemplary as expected and the CPU region is not cramped. The Northbridge cooler integrates two nozzles that are meant to be used along with a liquid cooling kit. In fact the heatsink on the Northbridge is hollow so it doubles as a water block. ASUS allows for very fine tweaking of CPU and memory voltages; in fact the Striker 2 NSE and Striker 2 Formula both allow one to fine tune the memory voltages in the tune of 0.02 volt steps while CPU volt steps are as fine as 0.006 volts. The Rampage Extreme is based on the X48 chipset also features the same fine adjustment to voltages. This board has an even larger heatpipe solution that the Striker boards and although the gun grey fins of the heatsinks look cool with the bright post-box red bezel atop the heatsink we found there to be too little space between the mosfet cooler and the CPU region. In fact getting the LGA 775 cooler on was a royal pain and our fingers were quite sore from battling with the large heatsinks all around the CPU region. Anyone who swaps out CPUs or coolers will rue this fact. That being said the board itself is well laid out aside from this one fault. The SATA ports are clear of

the PCIe slot and there are sets of three LEDs on the board that tell you the extent of overclocking; one each for none, moderate or extreme overclocking.

The ASUS P5E3 Premium is an X48 based, DDR3 supporting solution that's very easy on the eye. It features dual-WLAN APs and a really great quality build. The heatsink is attractive while not being overly blatant; the copper is well complimented by the shiny blue bezel that covers part of the cooling solution. Even though the cooling solution is large and surrounds the CPU socket on all four sides it doesn't interfere with installation of the CPU cooler which speaks volumes about ASUS' design standards. This board also features ASUS' Express Gate, which we discussed earlier. The ASUS P5E64 WS Evolution was the only self confessed workstation board in test. We really liked the heatsink/heatpipe look. For once ASUS decided to ditch the copper look and the heatpipes and cooling fins are chromed. The heatsinks also have shiny blue bezels and the overall effect this creates is one of supreme class. You'll notice this board amongst all the others around here. Although the heatpipes seem to cramp the CPU region

Buying Guide			
You need	We Recommend	Price	Why we Recommend it
A well built motherboard that's not too costly and is feature rich, budget Rs 12000	ECS P45T-AD3	Rs. 7,560	It's the cheapest P45 chipset board around and is well laid out and reasonably well built
Something flashy and feature rich and fast. I do not want multiple graphics card solutions	ASUS P5Q3 Deluxe	Rs. 13,850	Extremely well built and very feature rich, very fast, lots of flaunt value, overclockable too
An SLI solution that's well priced	ZOTAC NF-780i Supreme	Rs. 12,999	Well priced for a 780i solution and a good package too
A 3-way SLI solution with lots of features, flaunt value and great build quality	ASUS Striker 2 NSE	Rs. 21,250	The most feature rich and well built 790i SLI board around, and its better priced than some of the other boards that aren't as good
The Best Crossfire solution around but one that's not insanely priced	ASUS Rampage Formula; MSI X48c Platinum	Rs. 17,000; Rs. 15,000	The former is very well built and feature rich and definitely an option for even overclockers as its rock stable. The latter is the only board to support DDR2 and DDR3 making it a very flexible solution. And they both do Crossfire with x16 PCIe bandwidth
The best board for my Phenom Processor	ASUS M3A79-T Deluxe	Rs. 11,925	Four-way Crossfire support, plenty of expansion options and a well built board; cannot match this one for features and price

at first glance, installation of the CPU cooler was quite easy and our fingers hardly even touched the heatpipes. A PCIe x4 slot is provided above the primary PCIe graphics slot but the memory banks will interfere with longer cards that you can place in this slot. Surprisingly even this board has really decent overclocking options (for a workstation board).

Gigabytes two offerings; the X48-DQ6 and the EP45-DQ6 are X48 and P45 based boards respectively. Shockingly the EP45-DQ6 is costlier than the X48-DQ6 which is surprising because the latter is a full fledged x16 bandwidth providing Crossfire chipset meant for high-end gaming systems. Both boards are well laid out although the EP45-DQ6 does have an issue with the clearance between a full length PCIe card and the third and fourth SATA ports which become unusable. The first and second SATA ports are right under the card but since they face outwards installing a SATA cable isn't an issue here. Even though this board has quite an elaborate heatpipe solution the board gets quite hot. The other three 790i SLI boards were from EVGA, XFX and ZOTAC; once again all three were identical in terms of looks and layout, all being designed around the reference NVIDIA PCB design. Once again ZOTAC bundles a WLAN AP kit with their 790i.

Performance

ASUS' P5E64 WS Evolution was the fastest amongst these boards. Once again all the X48 boards tie up just behind it followed by the Gigabyte EP45-DQ6 and then NVIDIA's 790i SLI solutions.

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ASUS Striker 2 NSE

Surprisingly the 790i SLI does manage to impress in the PC Mark 05 graphics score where boards based on this chipset cracked the 19,000 point barrier. However, when we used 3D Mark 06, this advantage ceases leaving us to wonder what exactly in the benchmark favoured these boards.

Winner(s)

Our Best Buy belonged to the ASUS Striker 2 NSE. For Rs. 21,250 you get a board that supports 3-way SLI, is very well built and attractive looking and even comes with the full version of S.T.A.L.K.E.R. Shadow Of Chernobyl and 3D Mark 2006 Advanced Edition, plus Kaspersky Antivirus. It also has an LCD poster which connects to a USB port and displays the POST status on its screen; useless some might say, but downright funky. It's a feature-rich board that will not disappoint someone looking for a truly high-end machine. It also has a very good audio solution in the Soundmax ADI 1988B chipset, which is much better than the other sound solutions available with the exception of the Creative X-Fi series which we didn't see this year. ■

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